

A riddle within a riddle

In **Judges 14** Samson puts forth a riddle to the thirty companions. But, what you may not have noticed is that there is a “riddle” within Samson’s riddle:

Judges 14:10-18

10 ¶ So his father went down unto the woman: and Samson made there a feast; for so used the young men to do.

11 And it came to pass, when they saw him, that they brought thirty companions to be with him.

12 And Samson said unto them, I will now put forth a riddle unto you: if ye can certainly declare it me **within the seven days of the feast**, and find it out, then I will give you thirty sheets and thirty change of garments:

13 But if ye cannot declare it me, then shall ye give me thirty sheets and thirty change of garments. And they said unto him, Put forth thy riddle, that we may hear it.

14 And he said unto them, Out of the eater came forth meat, and out of the strong came forth sweetness. And they could not in **three days** expound the riddle.

15 And it came to pass on the seventh day, that they said unto Samson's wife, Entice thy husband, that he may declare unto us the riddle, lest we burn thee and thy father's house with fire: have ye called us to take that we have? is it not so?

16 And Samson's wife wept before him, and said, Thou dost but hate me, and lovest me not: thou hast put forth a riddle unto the children of my people, and hast not told it me. And he said unto her, Behold, I have not told it my father nor my mother, and shall I tell it thee?

17 And she wept before him the seven days, while their feast lasted: and it came to pass **on the seventh day**, that he told her, because she lay sore upon him: and she told the riddle to the children of her people.

18 And the men of the city said unto him **on the seventh day before the sun went down**, What is sweeter than honey? and what is stronger than a lion? And he said unto them, If ye had not plowed with my heifer, ye had not found out my riddle.

- Before the seven day feast begins, Samson puts forth his riddle.
- On the seventh day, the companions threaten Samson’s unnamed wife for the answer to the riddle.
- All seven days of the feast she wept before him and on the seventh day:

If you stop and think about what we just read for a moment, at first there appears to be a riddle in the midst:

Seven days of the feast her weeping did occur, How then on the seventh did the thirty threaten her?

How did she weep before him all seven days of the feast if they didn’t threaten her until the seventh day? 🧐

Let’s start over because the “solution” to this apparent riddle is more obvious if we look closely 🔍.

- Samson declares the riddle **before** the seven day feast begins. That means they were gathered together **before** the seven days of the feast began. *How long*, exactly?
 - Take careful note of the exact words in verse **15**: it doesn’t say “on the seventh day *of the feast*”. It says “on the seventh day”. We might understand that as “on the seventh day *before the feast began*”.
 - And so the answer to “*How long*, exactly?” is: seven days.
- Thus, the answer to the riddle within the riddle is that there were seven days preceding the seven day feast.